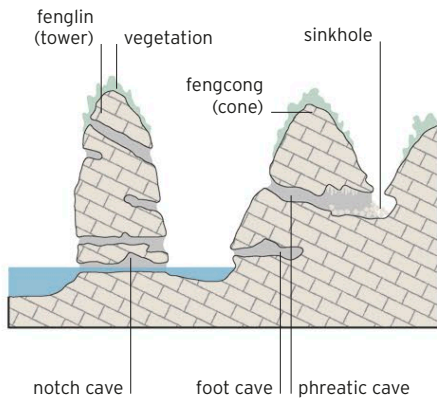


CONES, TOWERS, AND CAVES

Much of the Ha Long Bay karst consists either of large, cone-shaped blocks (known as fengcong), or isolated, towerlike islands (called fenglin). Cave types include wave-eroded notch caves at sea level, horizontal foot caves just above sea level, and larger, much older caves called phreatic caves, which are well above sea level.



▽ TRANQUIL WATERS

A group of kayakers ply their way between karst islands that rise up to 660 ft (200 m) above the waters of the bay.



Shiraho Reef

A Japanese coral reef of world-class importance in terms of biodiversity, home to a unique type of coral



Stretching to 2 miles (3 km), Shiraho Reef first came to notice in the 1980s as an example of biodiversity, with some 120 species of corals and 300 fish species. It also contains the world's largest colony of an unusual species of coral known as blue coral. This belongs to a group known

as octocorals, whose colonies mostly have flexible, branching skeletons. However, blue coral has a hard, rigid skeleton. Unfortunately, the reef's coral coverage has greatly decreased in recent years, but efforts are being made to conserve it.



◁ BRANCHING CORAL

The vertical plates of blue coral can form massive colonies. Despite its name, its color varies from blue through turquoise and green to yellow-brown.

Dragon Hole

The world's deepest underwater sinkhole, located on a reef in the South China Sea



Dragon Hole is just over 980 ft (300 m) deep. Its great depth was realized only when it was measured for the first time in 2016—previously, a sinkhole called Dean's Blue Hole in the Bahamas, which is 663 ft (202 m) deep, held the record for the world's deepest blue hole. Blue holes are sinkholes that form through erosional processes in blocks of limestone—while the limestone is on dry land and before the holes are flooded by sea-level rise. Local fishermen believe this is where the Monkey King found his golden cudgel in the 16th-century Chinese novel *Journey to the West*.

▷ BLUE EYE

Viewed from above, the hole looks dark blue due to its great depth compared to the light blue of the water on top of the reef.

